himself another martini, brow furrowed. He returned to his seat, drink in one hand and some peanuts in the other. “I guess the point is that whether or not I think a person far away has branched, it doesn’t make any difference to them. I can think of them as being just one copy, or as two copies that are absolutely identical. It’s just a matter of description.”

“Exactly!” Alice exclaimed. “Whether we think about branching as propagating outward at the speed of light or happening all at once is just a question of what’s most convenient. It’s no more worrisome than the fact that we can measure length in centimeters or inches.”

Her father rolled his eyes. “What kind of barbarian measures length in inches?”

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“Okay, let’s shift gears,” he said after a moment. “I know that string theorists and other people who aren’t very tethered to reality are fond of talking about extra dimensions. Do the branches live there? Where are these other worlds located, anyway?”

“Oh, come on, Robert.” Alice tended to call her father by his first name when she was annoyed with him. “You know better than that. The branches aren’t ‘located’ anywhere. If you’re stuck thinking of things as having locations in space, it might seem natural to ask about where the other worlds are. But there is no ‘place’ where those branches are hiding; they simply exist simultaneously, along with our own, effectively out of contact with it. I suppose they exist in Hilbert space, but that’s not really a ‘place.’ There are more things in heaven and earth than are dreamt of in your philosophy.” She was proud to keep her references Shakespearean.

“Yeah, I know. We’re a couple of drinks in, I thought I should toss you a softball.”

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He scrolled down the document on his phone a bit. “All right, let’s get more serious here. This one has been bugging me forever. What about conservation of energy? Where does all that *stuff* come from when you suddenly create a whole new universe?”